



Protecting Your Intellectual Property

Your intellectual property (IP), which you have created in your mind, can range from original ideas to inventions. It is vital to protect your IP in order to stop competitors from copying or stealing it.

Keeping ideas safe

Exactly what counts as intellectual property varies from country to country (see pp.212–215), although it typically includes product inventions, artistic works, pieces of fiction, commercial images (such as photographs or illustrations), and brand names.

The type of protection available to you will depend on the nature of the work. Some works are automatically granted protection—for example, copyright for literary

works and sound recordings. Some protections, such as trademarks and patents (see below), you will need to apply for. The relevant body in your country will handle these applications. Take care that your idea does not infringe on another's IP, particularly where other people's ideas have inspired you.

Consider the type of protection best suited to your needs. Single patents protect rights only in individual countries, so you may need to take out more than one.

Types of IP

An invention or idea is the basis of your success, and protecting this intellectual property could determine your long-term profitability. Businesses of any size, and individuals, can use IP protection. There are five main types of intellectual property: patents, trademarks, copyright, registered designs, and trade secrets. Depending on the specific IP, more than one type of protection might be necessary.

